Parental Consent

By S.D. Graubert

CHARACTERS: *EDNA, forty, proud, confident, highly strung.*
DANIELLA, seventeen, Edna's daughter, eager, patriotic.
NOTE: *A slash "/" indicates where dialogue should overlap.*

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Your child tells you they have decided to join the military to serve our country.*
ACTRESS 2: *Immediately, your heart falls deep into the pit of your stomach, and you begin to think you are losing your hearing.*
ACTRESS 1: *This rush of emotion is something you have never experienced before –*
ACTRESS 2: *Fear . . .*
ACRESS 2: *Faith . . .*
ACTRESS 1: *Pride . . .*
ACTRESS 2: *Shock . . .*
ACTRESS 1: *But at only 17, your child must have parental consent.*
ACTRESS 2: *What do you say?*
TOGETHER: *Parental Consent by S.D. Graubert*

Daniella helps Edna unpack groceries.

EDNA: So, I finally had to tell Mrs. Brody, I had to say it, and you know I don't like talking politics with the patients, but she kept on and on, 'til finally I said, and I didn't say it badly, but I had to say, I had to say it, I am proud of my country - no, that goes in a baggy - I am proud of how the Republicans are protecting my country, I wasn't angry, I mean I didn't say it angry, I was angry inside, she's clearly ignorant, does she want this country to be ruled by terrorists?

DANIELLA: They attacked us. So, we should -

EDNA: Exactly. They attacked us. She thinks it's all a conspiracy. About a, a, what'd she say? Pipeline. She thinks everything's a conspiracy. Oh, and the September attack was about oil. Oil? And I say to her, I say, there was no

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

oil in the World Trade Towers. There was no oil in the Pentagon.

DANIELLA: They want to destroy America

EDNA: They want to destroy America. Don't put the tomatoes in the fridge, they lose their flavor. I mean I told her, and I said it nicely, I didn't say it badly, in her day women didn't get to be doctors, not without it being an issue, she knows this, but we fight, we inch forward and you, you get to be a doctor *I* you get to be the

DANIELLA: Yeah, hey, and you also -

EDNA: one calling the shots, you can't do that in those countries, in Saudi Arabia, with the head scarves - because this is America. This is America.

DANIELLA: What'd she say to that?

EDNA: Well, she said ... *(Dismissive* exhalation.) Phoo ... but I said that's not racist, women don't have rights in Saudi Arabia, it's a fact, that's not racist, they don't have birth or death certificates, is it racist to comment, to observe that women don't have rights over there, no birth or death certificates? That's, that's like cattle. That's not racist.

DANIELLA: Women have rights in America.

EDNA: Everyone has rights in America. Our kids can be whatever, president, doctor - I'm so proud of you, Danny. Yeah. Her nephew signed up, Mrs. Brody, there's been a, a what do you call it, recruitment drive, at the mall, that's why she being so ... she wishes he hadn't. We upped her meds.

DANIELLA: For the marines?

EDNA: I guess. I said where do you think our soldiers come from? Look! It's an odor-buster! Then she says the whole WMD thing is an excuse, and I say, do you honestly, honestly think the president would lie about a thing like that? I said it's a good thing your nephew signed up, / you should be proud. / Our rights have to be protected. Because there's a whole

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

DANIELLA: Yeah. *(Second interruption.)* Yeah, proud!

EDNA: big part of the world that would like to take that away.

DANIELLA: That is so right.

EDNA: I don't want to be forced to wear a head scarf Do you?

DANIELLA: No way.

EDNA: She says it's not about head scarves, I say what's it about then? These potatoes, they had a demo in the store, they're purple inside. *(Cutting potata.)* You know how hard my job would be if I had to wear a head scarf? Look! That's pretty, right?

DANIELLA: Hey, Ma, can you sign this?

EDNA: Sure, ach, fingers. I thought we'd done all the paperwork.

DANIELLA: It's kinda like permission.

EDNA: You don't need my permission. You can do whatever you want.

DANIELLA: I'm not eighteen yet.

EDNA: Ten months.

DANIELLA: So, once you sign I'm good to go.

EDNA: Is this, like, for a society or something? Is that how it works now?

DANIELLA: I signed up.

EDNA: For extra credit? That's my girl.

DANIELLA: For the marines. (Beat.)

EDNA: How hard is it to pack a bag?

DANIELLA: I told him you'd be so into me going.

EDNA: Lighter groceries on top. It's not rocket science.

DANIELLA: Hey, not like Mrs. Brody!

EDNA: She crushed the cheese. Look at that.

DANIELLA: I'm gonna show them who's boss. Isn't it great, Ma?

EDNA: Yes. What is?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

DANIELLA: That I'm able to sign up. Same as Mrs. Brody's nephew.

EDNA: *(As if she is better.)* You are nothing like Mrs. Brody's nephew.

DANIELLA: Like, we're both marines.

EDNA: You're going to be doctor.

DANIELLA: See, it's cool. I get to be a doctor, and I get to be a marine. Right?

EDNA: But being a doctor is so much more impor -

DANIELLA: It's not an 'issue.' Like you said.

EDNA: People who join the marines have a propensity, they –

DANIELLA: He said I'm perfect marine material.

EDNA: And I'm sure they work very hard, but a doctor -

DANIELLA: They're an elite force. They're the vanguard of operations.

EDNA: Going to college is much -

DANIELLA: Yeah, and, like, the Taliban would stop me going to college. That's why we need to fight them.

EDNA: And there are people who do that. People who are trained.

DANIELLA: Oh, we get a full training.Twelve weeks / in Parris Island. Plus I get a $4000 sign up bonus. Then I get assigned. Afghanistan. Kosovo.

EDNA: Twelve weeks? *(After* Kosouo.) Kosovo? Is that even a country?

DANIELLA: It's, like, in Europe. Boring. Hey, can you sign? I need to get it back to him today.

EDNA: Today? But, but, doesn't this mean, aren't you, wouldn't this mean, you're going to be older, it'll put you at a disadvantage, if you, if your friends, aren't you going to be, if you -

DANIELLA: It'll make me a better doctor. That's what he said.

EDNA: *(Trying to stay* calm.) OK. It's a big decision. Why don't we think about this? For a couple of days. That's all. Just a couple of days.

DANIELLA: He says it's urgent.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

EDNA: Nothing good is done in haste.

DANIELLA: But we got attacked.

EDNA: New York! Washington! Nobody attacked Pittsburgh!

DANIELLA: Close enough.

EDNA: Yes, well, they didn't mean to land in Shanksville.

DANIELLA: If Al-Qaeda hadn't attacked America, it wouldn't have landed there at all. Look, they started it.

EDNA: I am aware of that, Daniella.

DANIELLA: I so want to get Osama Bin Laden.

EDNA: We all do, honey.

DANIELLA: Can you imagine? Yeah, I'm a woman and I'm kicking your Taliban butt!

EDNA: You're too young.

DANIELLA: No, see, you just have to sign the release. It's easy.

EDNA: There must be more to it than that.

DANIELLA: I read the leaflets. And spoke to the guy. For ages.

EDNA: But, see, don't you want to be with your friends? At college?

DANIELLA: They stop women being doctors out there, midwives, everything. You couldn't even be a nurse out there.

EDNA: No-one's going to stop you being a -

DANIELLA: The Taliban would. If they invaded. It was on the news! You know, Ma, you don't seem to be supporting my choice.

EDNA: I have always supported your choices.

DANIELLA: Then will you sign the form?

EDNA: Look. At least start college, just start it, do it for me, then in a couple of years-

DANIELLA: We might not have two years!

EDNA: But the money. It's set up. Do you know how hard I worked to secure that?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

DANIELLA: Yeah, I went through it all that with the recruiting officer.

EDNA: At the mall?

DANIELLA: Legally, they have to hold everything in place. 'Ti! I get back.

EDNA: What if you get injured? Have you even thought about that? *(She takes ice cream out of the bag.)*

DANIELLA: I'll be fine.

EDNA: The ice cream! I can't discuss this now, I have to defrost the fridge.

DANIELLA: I'll be fine, Ma.

EDNA: It has to be done now, or the ice cream will be ruined. *(Edna, very aggressively, empties out and sorts the remaining groceries.)* You could get raped. Sweet Jesus. They rape women out there.

DANIELLA: They rape women here.

EDNA: It's not the same! If you get caught by a, by a, a Taliban person, they'll-

DANIELLA: I won't get caught, Ma.

EDNA: It's war! You have no idea.

DANIELLA: I know about war, Ma, I am nearly eighteen.

EDNA: But what if you get. Danny, have you really thought? Or, or blinded, or you, or you, (*Her voice* <u>cracks.)</u> say, you don't come back? What's the point of holding a place, if you don't come back, Danny?

DANIELLA: God, why are you being so negative? Of course I'm gonna come back.

EDNA: You don't know!

DANIELLA: I thought I could count on you.

EDNA: Please, Danny, trust me, I know what's best for you.

DANIELLA: Doesn't look like it.

EDNA: Daniella. There are other people –

DANIELLA: Who do you think they are, Ma?

EDNA: It doesn't have to be -

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

DANIELLA: Mrs. Brody's nephew?

EDNA: What if she's right? I mean, it's, it's –

DANIELLA: So, now you think the president is lying?

EDNA: Of course not, I'm, I'm. I'm not saying it's. But what if?

DANIELLA: That my commander-in-chief is lying?

EDNA: Not your commander. He's not your commander.

DANIELLA: Only 'cause you won't sign the form.

EDNA: If, if, yes, what'd she say, the neo-con, the big event, like Pearl Harbor, that's what she said, then you'd have to wait, right? 'Til you knew for sure. About the pipeline. / Yes, she said that, I think, a pipeline. In Afghanistan.

DANIELLA: I can't believe you're - *(After "Afghanistan.")* I can't believe this. You said we had to fight, that we needed to protect -

EDNA: I know, I know, I know that. And I agree. But what if. Best to wait, couple of years, that's all. 'Til we know for sure.

DANIELLA: Our rights have to be protected, that's what you said. That's what you always say. You always say that!

EDNA: And Iraq. Well. That's a huge country.

DANIELLA: Ma! God. I can't believe - Anyway, we're not going into Iraq. That's what the guy said. He has it on official authority. I'm not supposed to tell you. Top secret.

EDNA: We're not going to get Saddam?

DANIELLA: Nope. And, hey, even if we did, he said it wouldn't take long. Didn't last time.

EDNA: Your allergies. Your hives. You'll be in Afghanistan with hives.

DANIELLA: He didn't say it would be a problem.

EDNA: *(Venom.)* Of course he didn't. He wouldn't.

DANIELLA: We've got to fight. / Inching forward. That's what you say.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

EDNA: Absolutely. The army should. That's why we pay our taxes.

DANIELLA: Sign the form, Ma.

EDNA: There's a lot of small print.

DANIELLA: It's not a warranty.

EDNA: You know I always read the small / print –

DANIELLA: I want to get it back to him today.

EDNA: Can't find my glasses.

DANIELLA: On your head.

EDNA: Pen doesn't work. *(Danny grabs a jar of pens.)*

DANIELLA: Here.

EDNA: I. I can't. I know it's. I'm sorry. I can't.

DANIELLA: I think you owe Mrs. Brody an apology.

EDNA: She's on strong medication.

DANIELLA: Then I give her more credit. *(Daniella storms out. Edna Looks at the document, lost.)*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: S.D. Graubert
Book: 2010 The Best 10-Minute Plays
ISBN: 978-1575257723
Publisher: Smith and Kraus
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2010

AWARD HISTORY

2016 National Qualifier